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The Maasai of Matapato

Author(S): Spencer, Paul

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 73

Culture (OWC): [Maasai \(FL12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: July 1976-September 1977

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage: Matapato, Kenya

Section Title(S): THE CIRCUMCISION ORDEAL

Immediately after a successful operation - with no flinching or admission of adultery - the initiate is offered stock by various close members of his family amounting to perhaps five or more cattle. He then gets up, and in doing so forfeits the right to further cattle on this occasion. He may therefore remain in the circumcision posture until he is satisfied that the gifts he has been promised match the wealth of his kinsmen and his own expectations as a herdboys who has served his family well. He is then carried or led backwards to his mother's hut by the man at his back. Other local elders have a clear idea how many cattle he can reasonably expect and if he stubbornly makes unrealistic demands, they will start to shout at him. In the final resort, he would simply be dragged backwards to his mother's hut, overriding his protests.

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Generally, there is a festive atmosphere surrounding a circumcision as described in the previous chapter, and the operation itself is quickly and efficiently dispatched, normally very early in the morning. Even so, it is a tense episode and a degree of confusion and anxiety appears to be an integral part of the ceremony, heightening the sense of occasion. Those close to the initiate and others that have recently been circumcised may deliberately try to provoke his anger, scorning and threatening him, and distancing themselves from him if he does flinch, but also firming his resolve not to do so. In his isolation, he is primed for the ordeal. For want of a Matapato example, it is useful to note an incident that occurred elsewhere.

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Case 11 .

 During a brief visit to the Siria Maasai where the age cycle was several years ahead of Matapato, a male circumcision was performed. At dawn,

a band of about ten initiates, who had recently recovered from the operation and wore their full regalia, led the youth from his mother's hut, singing and holding each arm. His movements were wooden and his face seemed drained of all vitality. The circumciser led him outside the village, smeared a line of chalk on either side of his own and the boy's eyes, and reminded him of the procedure (and of 74 his conditional curse?). The band of initiates then led him by the arm to a nearby spring to wash him and then returned. They paused at certain points, singing and making pointed references to the fact that none of them had flinched. At the father's gateway, he was left standing alone. Following Siria custom, instead of kicking over a pot of water, he was obliged to run from the gateway to his mother's hut where a firestick patron would souse him with water. Then he should snatch a hide and run with it to the circumciser waiting to operate in the middle of his father's corral. On this occasion, he rushed to his mother's hut, was soused and grabbed the hide, and then by mistake he rushed with it back to the gateway. Here, the other initiates grappled with him while he seemed to be fighting his way to leave the village. They dragged him struggling to the right spot, sat him on the hide, and the operation began promptly. Everyone's attention was drawn to the operation itself. No-one seemed to be watching whether he actually batted an eyelid or twitched a toe. An elderly woman (his mother?) with a close view of the operation was shivering throughout, a young elder (a close kinsman) who held his right leg during the operation looked quite shaken, and there was mild shivering among the band of initiates. The initiate himself remained expressionless and motionless. After the operation which lasted perhaps five minutes, he was given milk in a gourd to drink. The two elderly women spectators kissed his cheek, new sandals were placed on his feet, he was briefly offered cattle (the number appeared to have been agreed in detail beforehand) and then led backwards to his mother's hut.

The elders adjourned to a separate part of the hut to drink beer and joke about the operation emphasising gleefully to me how much it hurt: 'like fire!'. No-one suggested that the initiate had tried to run away, or that his shaken kinsman who held his leg felt that family honour had been tarnished. They argued that the initiate was just confused in his 'anger' and had lost his bearings, and that any kinsmen may feel distressed during the operation. Generally, there was satisfaction that the operation had been carried out without a hitch. The elders then called over smaller boys to tease them, playfully dragging them towards the doorway and asking them if they would like to be circumcised. Outside, catching this jocular mood, some women seized several young children. One of them started to prise out their lower incisors as if to emphasise to them the ordeal that awaited them, hooting with laughter while the children howled. (Maasai generally have denied that the ordeal of teeth-prising and circumcision are deliberately linked when I have discussed this episode with them).

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu

